Meta Platforms, Inc.

Core Ads Ripping, But So Is Opex & Capex

META's solid results were overshadowed by the increased investments, notably for MSL (the new AI team) which management noted is an uptick from just 90 days ago. While not surprising and likely to produce solid returns LT, this wipes out most of the expected OI growth in '26 and nearly all the FCF.

The Key Take-Away: META reported revenue that was 4% above consensus and guided towards even heavier investments. The company is behind on AI but the new team is well positioned to bring META back to the frontier, albeit with significant cost. Noted above, the increased capital intensity wipes out most FCF near term, but this isn't the permanent state; it's more of a temporary catch up. The high margin ad revenue is performing best-in-industry, so it pays for most of the MSL burn. While the pedigree of the new AI team is very good and they likely deliver vastly improved new models and products in '26, management is once again asking the investment community to patiently look across the near-term FCF implosion to the other side (which may be a few years out). Like previous investment cycles with increased competition, META shares likely remain a bit volatile here, but work higher over the longer term.

Positives in 3Q: Engagement across core FB, IG and Threads all seems to be improving on better content ranking and product updates. Advertising revenue accelerated to 25% ex-fx in 3Q on impression growth acceleration and across the board ad ranking and model improvements which are driving better system wide ad performance. The spread between META's ad revenue growth and Google's remains wide, a good proxy for share gains. META reiterated that there is ample room to run with ad model improvements, helping justify chunks of the hefty AI investments. $60B of the ad revenue (around 1/3) is running through near fully automated Advantage+, suggesting sustainable growth ahead as this penetration increases further.

Negative Items to Monitor: While not a complete surprise, the way META is characterizing the needed increases in capex to fund the new MSL team (a departure from "half going toward core AI" previously) moves the strategy out on the risk curve, where other AI labs live. This uptick in investment coupled with the Vibes launch (vs. Sora), which was the first project shipped externally by the new team, highlights this risk. The capex dollar growth is slated to be "notably larger" towards $115B+ next year, while total expenses grow "significantly faster" versus 2025, above the company's prior expectations. We expect calls for ROI on all this investment to only get louder going forward, but Zuckerberg did dangle a few carrots like external API and other product ideas that may be in the works, to help justify. And noted that this isn't trapped capex

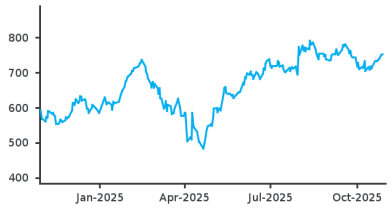
META	OVERWEIGHT Unchanged
U.S. Internet	POSITIVE Unchanged
Price Target	USD 770.00 lowered -5% from USD 810.00
Price (29-Oct-25)	USD 751.67
Potential Upside/Downside	+2.4%

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Market Cap (USD mn)	1888301
Shares Outstanding (mn)	2512.14
Free Float (%)	99.88
52 Wk Avg Daily Volume (mn)	14.1
Dividend Yield (%)	0.28
Return on Equity TTM (%)	40.65
Current BVPS (USD)	77.53

Source: Bloomberg

Price Performance	Exchange-Nasdaq
52 Week range	USD 796.25-479.80



Source: IDC
Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting

U.S. Internet

Ross Sandler
+1 415 263 4470
ross.sandler@barclays.com
BCI, US

Trevor Young, CFA
+1 212 526 3098
trevor.young@barclays.com
BCI, US

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at MSL, it can be easily repurposed to other internal projects or new external revenue areas as a backstop if needed.

Estimate Changes & Valuation: We slightly raise our revenue estimates in 2026 now reflecting +18% ex-fx advertising growth rate, which could still prove conservative. We significantly increase our operating expenses, in line with updated commentary on next year's expense growth. Our $770 price target (previously $810) is based on 25x EPS and 12x EBTIDA on our FY27E estimates (previously 25x EPS, 15x EBITDA and included 3% FCF yield, which has now been dropped given the capex ramp). We have lowered our EBITDA multiple to account for the reduced visibility amidst this investment cycle.

META: Quarterly and Annual EPS (USD)

	2024	2025			2026			Change y/y	
FY Dec	Actual	Old	New	Cons	Old	New	Cons	2025	2026
Q1	5.48A	6.96A	6.96A	6.43A	7.45E	7.13E	8.02E	27%	2%
Q2	6.49A	7.90A	7.90A	7.14A	8.46E	8.13E	9.14E	22%	3%
Q3	6.79A	7.85E	8.47A	8.43E	8.42E	8.30E	8.62E	25%	-2%
Q4	8.08A	9.18E	9.21E	9.51E	9.99E	9.45E	10.41E	14%	3%
Year	26.83A	31.88E	32.52E	35.37E	34.32E	33.02E	34.54E	21%	2%
P/E	28.0		23.1			22.8			

Consensus numbers are from Bloomberg received on 29-Oct-2025; 12:50 GMT
Source: Barclays Research

U.S. Internet POSITIVE

Meta Platforms, Inc. (META) OVERWEIGHT

Income statement ($bn)	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E	CAGR
Revenue	165	200	237	274	18.5%
Gross profit	135	165	190	218	17.2%
EBITDA (adj)	102	122	138	166	17.7%
EBIT (adj)	86	103	107	117	10.8%
Pre-tax income (adj) ($mn)	71	85	85	93	9.6%
Net income (adj)	70	84	86	94	10.3%
EPS (adj) ($)	26.83	32.52	33.02	35.95	10.2%
Diluted shares (bn)	2.6	2.6	2.6	2.6	0.0%
DPS ($)	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	N/A

Margin and return data	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E	Average
EBITDA (adj) margin (%)	61.8	60.7	58.3	60.5	60.3
EBIT (adj) margin (%)	52.4	51.3	45.1	42.8	47.9
Pre-tax (adj) margin (%)	43.0	42.5	35.7	33.9	38.8
Net (adj) margin (%)	42.5	41.9	36.0	34.2	38.7
ROIC (%)	20.1	26.6	19.7	19.1	21.4
ROE (%)	37.1	29.3	27.7	22.6	29.2

Balance sheet and cash flow ($bn)	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E	CAGR
Tangible fixed assets	121	178	262	358	43.4%
Intangible fixed assets	21	21	21	21	0.8%
Cash and equivalents	44	21	28	31	-10.8%
Total assets	276	332	429	533	24.5%
Short and long-term debt	29	29	29	29	0.0%
Other long-term liabilities	13	24	24	24	23.4%
Total liabilities	93	112	123	132	12.3%
Net debt/(funds)	-15	8	1	-2	N/A
Shareholders' equity	183	220	306	401	30.0%
Change in working capital	1	0	5	3	48.6%
Cash flow from operations	91	114	128	152	18.6%
Capital expenditure	-37	-71	-115	-144	N/A
Free cash flow	54	43	12	8	-46.3%

Valuation and leverage metrics	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E	Average
P/E (adj) (x)	28.0	23.1	22.8	20.9	23.7
EV/sales (x)	-0.1	0.1	0.0	0.0	0.0
EV/EBITDA (adj) (x)	-0.1	0.1	0.0	0.0	0.0
FCF yield (%)	-411.8	430.3	457.7	-1,931.7	-363.9
Dividend yield (%)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Net debt/EBITDA (adj) (x)	-0.1	0.1	0.0	0.0	0.0

Selected Operating Metrics ($)	2024A	2025E	2026E	2027E
Advertising revenue ($bn)	161	196	233	270
Payments & other fees revenue ($mn)	4	4	4	4
.				
DAUs (mn)	2,119	2,166	2,214	2,263
Advertising revenue per DAU	11.75	13.83	15.58	16.84
Payments & other fees revenue per DAU	0.46	0.49	0.48	0.50

Note: FY End Dec
Source: Company data, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Price (29-Oct-2025)	**USD 751.67**
Price Target	**USD 770.00**

Why OVERWEIGHT?

We believe META is the best pure play in consumer internet around mobile advertising and it continues to take a large share of mobile advertising budgets. We expect fundamentals to remain strong going forward.

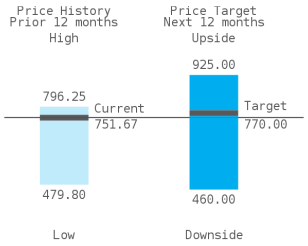
Upside case **USD 925.00**

As mobile monetization improves in the coming years, we expect META to benefit from this. We believe both core FB and Instagram have room to grow, and Whatsapp and Messenger will provide upside as META starts to monetize them in the coming years.

Downside case **USD 460.00**

The transition to video will negatively impact margins due to revenue sharing agreements. The company is also reaching a ceiling in terms of ad load in core FB.

Upside/Downside scenarios



META 3Q25 Earnings

FIGURE 1. 3Q25 Quarterly Comparison - Actual vs Barclays Estimates

Quarterly Comparison versus Barclays Estimates (USD in bn, unless noted)	3Q25 Actual	Barclays Estimate	Delta	Consensus	Prior Year Quarter	Change / Prior Year	Prior Quarter	Change / Prior Quarter
Key Metrics								
Advertising Revenue by Geography								
US & Canada	21.331	21.157	1%		17.389	23%	20.045	6%
Europe	12.072	11.889	2%		9.358	29%	11.366	6%
Asia	10.020	10.018	0%		8.050	24%	9.148	10%
ROW	6.659	6.660	0%		5.088	31%	6.004	11%
Total Advertising Revenue	**50.082**	**49.723**		**48.520**	**39.885**	**26%**	**46.563**	**8%**
FRL/Payments Revs	1.160	0.578	101%	0.589	0.704	65%	0.953	22%
Income Statement								
Net Revenue	**51.242**	**50.301**	**1.9%**	**49.490**	**40.589**	**26%**	**47.516**	**8%**
Cost of revenues	8.887	9.313	-5%		7.109	25%	8.213	8%
Gross Profit	42.355	40.988	3.3%	40.189	33.480	27%	39.303	8%
% Gross Margin	82.7%	81.5%	117 bps	81.0%	82.5%	17 bps	82.7%	-06 bps
Marketing & Sales	2.576	3.427	-25%		2.562	1%	2.745	-6%
Research & Development	10.455	10.286	2%		7.691	36%	8.862	18%
General & Administrative	3.234	2.016	60%		1.627	99%	2.421	34%
Total Operating Expenses	21.820	20.744	5%		16.130	35%	18.862	16%
GAAP Operating Income	20.535	20.244	1%	19.460	17.350	18%	20.441	0%
PF Operating Income	26.090	25.259	3%		21.600	21%	25.275	3%
Adjusted EBITDA	**31.053**	**30.875**	**0.6%**	**29.731**	**25.627**	**21%**	**29.617**	**5%**
% Margins	60.6%	61.4%	-78 bps		63.1%	-254 bps	62.3%	--
GAAP EPS	**$1.05**	**$6.84**	**-85%**	**$6.72**	**$6.03**	**-83%**	**$7.14**	**($0.85)**

Consensus via StreetAccount & Bloomberg
Source: Barclays Research, Company Reports

Estimate Changes

FIGURE 2. Estimate Changes

	4Q25E			2025E			2026E			2027E		
	New Est.	Old Est.	Delta	New Est.	Old Est.	Delta	New Est.	Old Est.	Delta	New Est.	Old Est.	Delta
Revs by segments												
Advertising Revenue	57.926	57.066	1.5%	195.963	194.744	0.6%	233.044	228.313	2.1%	269.571	265.506	1.5%
FRL and Payments Revenue	1.222	1.123	8.8%	4.257	3.576	19.1%	4.258	3.961	7.5%	4.494	4.122	9.0%
Net Revenues	**59.148**	**58.189**	**1.6%**	**200.220**	**198.320**	**1.0%**	**237.302**	**232.274**	**2.2%**	**274.065**	**269.628**	**1.6%**
Cost of Revenues	10.907	10.875	0.3%	35.307	35.664	-1.0%	47.183	44.082	7.0%	55.860	52.519	6.4%
Gross Profit	48.241	47.314	2.0%	164.913	162.656	1.4%	190.119	188.192	1.0%	218.205	217.110	0.5%
Margin	81.6%	81.3%	25 bps	82.4%	82.0%	35 bps	80.1%	81.0%	-90 bps	79.6%	80.5%	-90 bps
Operating Expenses:												
Marketing & Sales	3.947	3.883	1.6%	11.789	12.535	-5.9%	16.350	15.836	3.2%	19.574	19.057	2.7%
Research & Development	11.786	11.304	4.3%	39.827	39.260	1.4%	54.330	50.152	8.3%	66.863	61.228	9.2%
General & Administrative	2.848	2.511	13.4%	10.570	9.009	17.3%	12.520	10.968	14.1%	14.449	13.272	8.9%
Stock-Based Compensation	5.210	4.835	7.8%	19.746	18.831	4.9%	22.212	20.897	6.3%	24.276	22.912	6.0%
Total Operating Expenses	23.792	22.533	5.6%	81.932	79.635	2.9%	105.411	97.854	7.7%	125.162	116.469	7.5%
Operating Income - GAAP	24.450	24.781	-1.3%	82.981	83.021	0.0%	84.708	90.338	-6.2%	93.042	100.641	-7.6%
Non-GAAP Operating Income	**29.660**	**29.615**	**0.2%**	**102.727**	**101.852**	**0.9%**	**106.920**	**111.235**	**-3.9%**	**117.319**	**123.553**	**-5.0%**
Depreciation & Amortization	5.677	6.535	-13.1%	18.882	20.393	-7.4%	31.326	32.575	-3.8%	48.515	47.904	1.3%
Stock Based Compensation	5.210	4.835	7.8%	19.746	18.831	4.9%	22.212	20.897	6.3%	24.276	22.912	6.0%
Adjusted EBITDA	**35.336**	**36.150**	**-2.3%**	**121.608**	**122.244**	**-0.5%**	**138.246**	**143.810**	**-3.9%**	**165.834**	**171.458**	**-3.3%**
Margin	59.7%	62.1%	-238 bps	60.7%	61.6%	-90 bps	58.3%	61.9%	-366 bps	60.5%	63.6%	-308 bps
Pretax Income - GAAP	**24.450**	**24.781**	**-1.3%**	**85.029**	**83.941**	**1.3%**	**84.708**	**90.338**	**-6.2%**	**93.042**	**100.641**	**-7.6%**
Income Tax Expense (benefit)	3.178	3.221	-1.3%	26.067	9.788	166.3%	11.859	12.647	-6.2%	13.026	14.090	-7.6%
Reported Net Income	21.271	21.559	-1.3%	58.961	74.152	-20.5%	72.849	77.691	-6.2%	80.016	86.551	-7.6%
GAAP Earnings per Share	$8.25	$8.36	-1.2%	$22.88	$28.75	-20.4%	$28.13	$29.96	-6.1%	$30.65	$33.11	-7.4%

Source: Barclays Research, Company Reports

Valuation

FIGURE 3. **META Valuation**

Meta -- Valuation Worksheet

($ in billions, except per share amounts)

Current Price (After Hours)	$696.30		
Diluted Shares Outstanding	2.6		
Current Market Cap	1791		
Less: Cash and Cash Equivalents	44.4		
Plus: Debt	28.8		
Enterprise Value	1775.3		
Price to Earnings	**2025E**	**2026E**	**2027E**
GAAP EPS	$22.88	$28.13	$30.65
Current P/E multiple	30.4x	24.8x	22.7x
Target Multiple	**25.0x**	**25.0x**	**25.0x**
Implied Stock Price on Forward EPS	**$570**	**$705**	**$765**
EV to EBITDA	**2025E**	**2026E**	**2027E**
Adjusted EBITDA	121.6	138.2	165.8
Current EV/EBITDA Multiple	14.6x	12.8x	10.7x
Target Multiple	**12.0x**	**12.0x**	**12.0x**
Enterprise Value	1459.3	1659.0	1990.0
Plus: YE Cash	55.0	62.3	65.5
Less: YE Debt	28.8	28.8	28.8
Less: Minority Interest	0.0	0.0	0.0
Equity Market Capitalization	1485.5	1692.4	2026.6
FY End Projected Sharecount	2.6	2.6	2.6
Implied Stock Price on Forward EBITDA	**$575**	**$655**	**$775**
	$575	**$680**	**$770**
			$770

Source: Barclays Research, Company Reports. Price as of 8:00PM EST on 10/29/25.

FIGURE 4. META Income Statement

Meta -- Quarterly Earnings Analysis	Dec-22	Dec-23	Dec-24	Mar-25	Jun-25	Sep-25	Dec-25	Dec-25	Dec-26	Dec-27
FY End December	2022A	2023A	2024A	1QA	2QA	3QA	4QE	2025E	2026E	2027E
Advertising revenue	113.641	131.948	160.632	41.392	46.563	50.082	57.926	195.963	233.044	269.571
Payments and other fees revenue	2.968	2.953	3.868	0.922	0.953	1.160	1.222	4.257	4.258	4.494
Net revenue	**116.609**	**134.901**	**164.500**	**42.314**	**47.516**	**51.242**	**59.148**	**200.220**	**237.302**	**274.065**
Cost of Revenues	24.481	25.218	29.107	7.301	8.213	8.887	10.907	35.307	47.183	55.860
Gross Profit	**92.128**	**109.683**	**135.393**	**35.013**	**39.303**	**42.355**	**48.241**	**164.913**	**190.119**	**218.205**
Operating Expenses:										
Marketing & Sales	14.257	11.349	10.321	2.521	2.745	2.576	3.947	11.789	16.350	19.574
Research & Development	25.978	27.054	30.189	8.723	8.862	10.455	11.786	39.827	54.330	66.863
General & Administrative	10.957	10.502	8.813	2.067	2.421	3.234	2.848	10.570	12.520	14.449
Stock-Based Compensation	11.991	14.027	16.690	4.147	4.834	5.555	5.210	19.746	22.212	24.276
Amortization of Intangibles	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Total Operating Expenses	63.183	62.932	66.013	17.458	18.862	21.820	23.792	81.932	105.411	125.162
Operating Income	28.945	46.751	69.380	17.555	20.441	20.535	24.450	82.981	84.708	93.042
Depreciation & Amortization	8.686	11.177	15.498	3.900	4.342	4.963	5.677	18.882	31.326	48.515
Stock Based Compensation	11.991	14.027	16.690	4.147	4.834	5.555	5.210	19.746	22.212	24.276
Adjusted EBITDA	**53.820**	**77.277**	**101.705**	**25.602**	**29.617**	**31.053**	**35.336**	**121.608**	**138.246**	**165.834**
Interest expense	(0.126)	0.677	1.284	0.827	0.093	1.128	0.000	2.048	0.000	0.000
Other (expense) income, net	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Pretax Income	28.819	47.428	70.664	18.382	20.534	21.663	24.450	85.029	84.708	93.042
Income Tax Expense (benefit)	5.620	8.331	8.304	1.738	2.197	18.954	3.178	26.067	11.859	13.026
Reported Net Income	23.199	39.097	62.360	16.644	18.337	2.709	21.271	58.961	72.849	80.016
Non-GAAP Operating Income	45.134	66.100	86.207	21.702	25.275	26.090	29.660	102.727	106.920	117.319
Non-GAAP Net Income	36.006	53.422	69.993	18.023	20.294	21.774	23.728	83.820	85.536	93.855
Diluted Earnings per Share										
GAAP Earnings per Share	$8.61	$14.92	$23.91	$6.43	$7.14	$1.05	$8.25	$22.88	$28.13	$30.65
Pro forma Earnings per Share	**$13.36**	**$20.39**	**$26.83**	**$6.96**	**$7.90**	**$8.47**	**$9.21**	**$32.52**	**$33.02**	**$35.95**
Diluted Shares Outstanding	2.696	2.620	2.609	2.590	2.570	2.572	2.577	2.577	2.590	2.611
Pro forma Shares Outstanding	2.696	2.620	2.609	2.590	2.570	2.572	2.577	2.577	2.590	2.611
Other Metrics										
Peer Defined Free Cash Flow	19.064	43.847	54.072	10.334	8.549	10.625	11.846	43.124	12.477	8.381
Free Cash Flow per Share	$7.07	$16.74	$20.73	$3.99	$3.33	$4.13	$4.60	$16.73	$4.82	$3.21
Margin Analysis										
Gross Profit Margin	79.0%	81.3%	82.3%	82.7%	82.7%	82.7%	81.6%	82.4%	80.1%	79.6%
Marketing & Sales as % of Net Revenue	12.2%	8.4%	6.3%	6.0%	5.8%	5.0%	6.7%	5.9%	6.9%	7.1%
Research & Development as % of Net Revenue	22.3%	20.1%	18.4%	20.6%	18.7%	20.4%	19.9%	19.9%	22.9%	24.4%
General & Administrative as % of Net Revenue	9.4%	7.8%	5.4%	4.9%	5.1%	6.3%	4.8%	5.3%	5.3%	5.3%
Total Operating Expenses as % of Net Revenue	54.2%	46.7%	40.1%	41.3%	39.7%	42.6%	40.2%	40.9%	44.4%	45.7%
Operating Margin	24.8%	34.7%	42.2%	41.5%	43.0%	40.1%	41.3%	41.4%	35.7%	33.9%
Non-GAAP Operating Margin	38.7%	49.0%	52.4%	51.3%	53.2%	50.9%	50.1%	51.3%	45.1%	42.8%
Adjusted EBITDA Margin	46.2%	57.3%	61.8%	60.5%	62.3%	60.6%	59.7%	60.7%	58.3%	60.5%
Incremental EBITDA Margin	750.8%	128.2%	82.5%	78.5%	60.1%	50.9%	44.6%	55.7%	44.9%	75.0%
Effective Tax Rate	19.5%	17.6%	11.8%	9.5%	10.7%	87.5%	13.0%	30.7%	14.0%	14.0%
Reported Net Income	19.9%	29.0%	37.9%	39.3%	38.6%	5.3%	36.0%	29.4%	30.7%	29.2%
Year Over Year Growth										
Advertising revenue	**-1.1%**	**16.1%**	**21.7%**	**16.2%**	**21.5%**	**25.6%**	**23.8%**	**22.0%**	**18.9%**	**15.7%**
Payments and other fees revenue	-0.9%	-0.5%	31.0%	12.4%	28.4%	64.8%	-23.7%	10.1%	0.0%	5.5%
Net Revenue	-1.1%	15.7%	21.9%	16.1%	21.6%	26.2%	22.2%	21.7%	18.5%	15.5%
Cost of Revenues	10.9%	3.0%	15.4%	13.7%	17.0%	25.0%	27.4%	21.3%	33.6%	18.4%
Gross Profit	-3.9%	19.1%	23.4%	16.6%	22.6%	26.5%	21.1%	21.8%	15.3%	14.8%
Operating Income	-38.1%	61.5%	48.4%	27.0%	37.7%	18.4%	4.6%	19.6%	2.1%	9.8%
Adjusted EBITDA	**-15.6%**	**43.6%**	**31.6%**	**21.9%**	**20.7%**	**21.2%**	**15.7%**	**19.6%**	**13.7%**	**20.0%**
Reported Net Income	-41.1%	68.5%	59.5%	34.6%	36.2%	-82.7%	2.1%	-5.5%	23.6%	9.8%
GAAP Earnings per Share	-37.1%	73.4%	60.2%	36.4%	38.3%	-82.5%	2.9%	-4.3%	22.9%	9.0%
Pro forma Earnings per Share	-14.9%	52.7%	31.6%	26.9%	21.7%	24.7%	13.9%	21.2%	1.5%	8.9%

Source: Barclays Research, Company Reports

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Primary Stocks (Ticker, Date, Price)
Meta Platforms, Inc. (META, 29-Oct-2025, USD 751.67), Overweight/Positive, CD/CE/J/K/M/N

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Match Group, Inc. (MTCH)	MercadoLibre (MELI)	Meta Platforms, Inc. (META)
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Meta Platforms, Inc. (META / META)

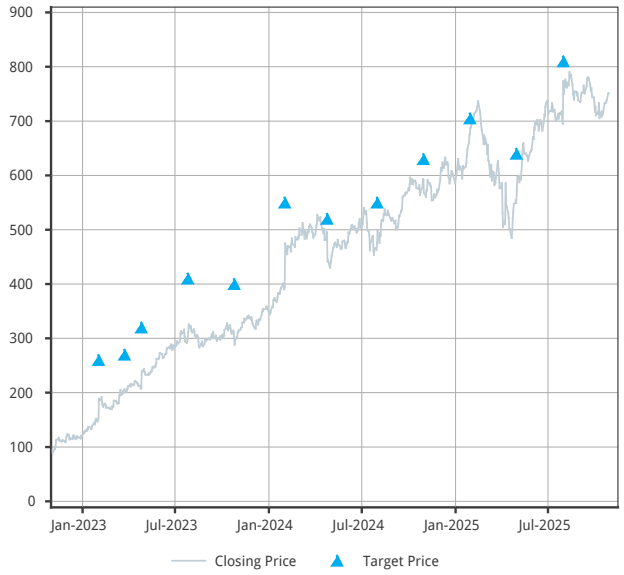
Stock Rating: **OVERWEIGHT**

Industry View: **POSITIVE**

Closing Price: **USD 751.67** (29-Oct-2025)

Rating and Price Target Chart - USD (as of 29-Oct-2025)

Currency=USD



Source: IDC, Barclays Research

Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting

Publication Date	Closing Price*	Rating	Adjusted Price Target
31-Jul-2025	695.21		810.00
30-Apr-2025	549.00		640.00
29-Jan-2025	676.49		705.00
30-Oct-2024	591.80		630.00
31-Jul-2024	474.83		550.00
24-Apr-2024	493.50		520.00
01-Feb-2024	394.78		550.00
25-Oct-2023	299.53		400.00
26-Jul-2023	298.57		410.00
26-Apr-2023	209.40		320.00
24-Mar-2023	204.28		270.00
01-Feb-2023	153.12		260.00

On 29-Oct-2022, prior to any intra-day change that may have been published, the rating for this security was Overweight, and the adjusted price target was 165.00.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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Valuation Methodology: Our $770 price target is based on an average of 25x EPS and 12x EBITDA on our FY27E estimates.

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U.S. Internet

Alex Hughes
+1 212 526 3069
alexander.hughes@barclays.com
BCI, US

Joseph Petroline
+1 212 526 6382
joseph.petroline@barclays.com
BCI, US

Michael DiSanto
+1 212 526 1054
michael.disanto@barclays.com
BCI, US

Owen Clendenin
+1 212 526 7518
owen.clendenin@barclays.com
BCI, US

Alexander Kessinger
+1 212 526 1324
alexander.kessinger@barclays.com
BCI, US